WEDNESDAY, SEPTEMBER 9, 2026

www.punemirror.com

Pune Times Mirror

Mumbai

Edition

Sensex 77,577 | Nifty 23,635

Gold 1,55,350 | Silver 2,50,000

Dollar 94.49 | Euro 109.74

GBP 127.65

10 Pages Invitation PRICE Rs 5

MAX 31 | MIN 26 | HUMIDITY 72%

Inside Mirror



BANDRA GETS READY FOR MOUNT MARY FAIR

Pedestrian safety under spotlight

Dombivli market razed



Sarnaik – Mehta slugfest

IT'S AN OPEN WAR NOW

Pratap Sarnaik

Narendra Mehta

| Tushar Shete
tushar.shete@punemirror.com
@ThePuneMirror

Even as everything appeared calm within the ruling Mahayuti alliance, comprising the Shiv Sena and the BJP in the main, a dispute between minister Pratap Sarnaik of the Sena and Narendra Mehta of the BJP has flared up. While tensions between Mehta and Sarnaik are not new, the mutual allegations exchanged over the past few days have turned what was a cold war between the two into an open war.

Sarnaik's assembly constituency is Owala Majiwada, but a part of the Mira Bhayandar Municipal Corporation area falls within it. This has kept the rivalry between Sarnaik and Mehta alive for years. However, the friction eased somewhat during the period when Geeta Jain was the MLA and the corporation was under administrator rule. With Narendra Mehta's re-election in 2024 and the BJP recently coming to power in the municipal corporation elections, both leaders have once again taken an aggressive stance. Since both are politicians and builders by profession, their allegations against each other are closely tied to the construction business.

Sarnaik's allegation

Transport Minister Pratap Sarnaik visited the municipal corporation on Monday, where he levelled allegations against the Seven Eleven company and against former police officer Ravindra Sawant. He questioned how a retired police officer could become a builder and how he could invest crores of rupees in the Seven Eleven company linked to Narendra Mehta. Sarnaik made a serious allegation that despite a court order, the corporation had illegally granted permission to a construction project involving BJP MLA Narendra Mehta's Seven Eleven company. He said this amounted to contempt of court and demanded that the entire transaction be investigated by the Economic Offences Wing (EOW), along with a review of all building permissions granted by the corporation.

He also directed the police to seize the project's file. Sarnaik further alleged that the project's architect, Yash Kothari, is Narendra Mehta's nephew, and claimed that Mehta's son is also involved in the project. He, therefore, demanded an investigation into both the land dealings and the permissions granted.

"This is a major financial irregularity, and an attempt is being made to tarnish the image of the Mahayuti government through it. Therefore, there must be a fair investigation into this matter," Sarnaik said.

Mehta hit back sharply at Sarnaik's allegations. "Pratap Sarnaik is making baseless allegations. The Seven Eleven company always operates as per rules. If a man who drove a bhurji-pav cart thirty-five years ago can become a minister and amass wealth worth billions, then why can't a police officer earn money through business after retirement?" Mehta asked.

I taught Mehta Marathi: Sarnaik

Transport Minister Pratap Sarnaik hit back sharply at Narendra Mehta after the BJP MLA's fresh criticism, taking a direct jibe at his educational background and Marathi language skills. "He studied only till the fourth standard. It was I who somehow managed to teach him Marathi. Only I know how much effort that took," Sarnaik said, sparing no punches. "If he wants to learn Marathi properly, he should come to me, sit down, fold his hands, place a finger on his lips, and learn it the right way."

Mehta added that all of Sarnaik's allegations are baseless and without any substance, and that his company conducts all its work strictly by the rules. "Sarnaik is a minister. How can someone holding a ministerial post behave so childishly?" Mehta asked, referring to Ravindra Sawant. He clarified that the Seven Eleven company mentioned by Sarnaik has no connection whatsoever with his own company.

Furthermore, he said that public trust in Sarnaik is low, pointing out that only three of Sarnaik's corporators won in the recent municipal corporation elections, and suggested Sarnaik should reflect on why his party's seats declined. Mehta remarked, "It is our misfortune that Sarnaik is in the alliance, and my misfortune that Sarnaik is the elected representative of Mira Bhayandar." He accused Sarnaik of obstructing the city's development instead of contributing to it.

RELIGIOUS GROUP'S VISIT TO EIFFEL TOWER SPARKS CONTROVERSY

| Roshan Bourget/Paris
feedback@ptmmumbai.com
@ThePTMMumbai

The controversy over the visit of Swaminarayan sect devotees to the world-renowned Eiffel Tower on Monday was to be expected. Understandably, it has become the talking point all over France.

The group had paid for a special tour of the tower, and it insisted that women staffers not be seen around during the visit. In a gross error of judgment, the Société d'Exploitation de la tour Eiffel, which manages the popular tourist attraction, most unthinkingly agreed to the stipulation of the group. It should have known that its women employees would not take kindly to the suggestion to keep them in hiding during the Swaminarayan devotees' visit.

The sect does have a tradition as per which there is strict segregation of male and female devotees. Its sadhus are not supposed to even look at women, let alone interact with them. They follow a strict code of celibacy. Those who believe in gender justice may characterise this policy as being misogynistic, and progressive sections the world over will agree with this perception.

In a country like France, which is justly known for its vigorous liberal ethos, stipulations such as the one insisted upon by Swaminarayan followers have no place. The staff Union has protested against the management's highly controversial decision. It won't be surprising if heads roll at the tower management.



PHOTO: WIKIPEDIA

Bridge work paces up

Gaimukh-Payegaon link crosses milestone; boost for Thane connectivity

Rutuja Joshi
feedback@punemirror.com
@ThePuneMirror



The piling work is more than 95 per cent complete and pier and pier-cap construction is also progressing

Work on the ambitious Gaimukh-Payegaon Creek Bridge has gained momentum, with construction of the key creek portion nearing a major milestone, according to an update shared by the Mumbai Metropolitan Region Development Authority (MMRDA).

The 6.5-km elevated road and creek bridge is being developed as a crucial missing link between Gaimukh in Thane and Payegaon on the Anjur-Chinchoti Road. MMRDA's latest update indicates that piling work on the creek section is more than 95 per cent complete, while pier and pier-cap construction is also progressing. Overall physical progress of the project has crossed the 20 per cent mark.

The project is expected to provide a more direct route towards Chinchoti, Payegaon, Bhiwandi and Vasai, reducing the dependence on existing routes around Ghodbunder Road and the Fountain Hotel-Chinchoti stretch. According to MMRDA, the present journey between Gaimukh and Payegaon is about 31.5 km and can take nearly 1.5 hours.

Once completed, the four-lane elevated corridor will begin near Thane Creek at Gaimukh and terminate near Payegaon village. Along its alignment, it will cross several major transport infrastructure corridors, including the Mumbai-Ahmedabad High Speed Rail project, the proposed Multimodal Corridor, the Diva-Vasai railway line, the Dedicated Freight Corridor and the Anjur-Chinchoti Road.

The bridge is being positioned as more than a standalone road project. It is expected to strengthen links between several ongoing and proposed transportation networks in the Mumbai Metropolitan Region, potentially improving movement between Thane, Bhiwandi, Vasai and other northern parts of the region.

For commuters, one of the major expected benefits is the possibility of bypassing the congested Ghodbunder route and its ghat section when travelling towards Chinchoti and Payegaon. The new connection could also provide an alternative route for commercial and freight traffic, easing pressure on existing roads.

The project received administrative approval in March 2024. MMRDA appointed Ashoka Buildcon as the contractor and Sheladia Associates as the project management consultant in October 2024. The project has an estimated length of 6.509 km and a construction period of 30 months following design and environmental approval activities.

The approved project cost is listed by MMRDA at Rs. 1,551.18 crore, while the project cost excluding GST is stated as Rs. 975.58 crore on its project details page.



FROM THE EDITOR'S DESK

Pune Times Mirror, Mumbai
S Balakrishnan

BEST can still be made the best

The death of a 60-year-old woman, who was crushed under the wheels of a BEST bus at Worli on Monday, once again shows the virtual collapse of the undertaking's management. Since January, 2026, over 250 persons have been killed and many more injured in accidents involving BEST buses. Significantly, most of these culprit buses have been taken on wet lease without any consideration of the track record of drivers and the condition of vehicles.

The cold reality is that the BEST, which was the best-managed public transport undertaking, is today a pale shadow of its earlier self. It had two wings, dealing with electricity and transport. The profit generated by the electricity wing was used to offset losses incurred by the transport department.

The Undertaking had a near monopoly over the sale of electricity in the island city. But the government's decision to end the monopoly dealt a body blow to the Undertaking. On top of all, the BEST had a totally corrupt official who virtually cannibalised the organisation. Is the BEST beyond redemption? The answer is an emphatic 'no.' Even now, it is not too late to revive the organisation. Its monopoly in power distribution should be restored by amending the Electricity Act, and a visionary and non-corrupt official should be put in charge. The trade unions should be taken into confidence and made to feel that they are on the same page as the management. If the government has the will, then the organisation can be made the best in the country. Mumbaikars certainly deserve a better public bus transport system.

Factories under lens

Unidentified units raise questions over licensing

Varad A. Gokhale
feedback@punemirror.com
@ThePuneMirror

Questions are being raised over the functioning of industrial units around Government Polytechnic College, Thane, after a visit to one of the factories on Tuesday morning found no visible nameplate or licence number at its entrance. The absence of basic identification details, coupled with the reluctance of workers to disclose the name of the company or its owner, has raised concerns over who is monitoring these establishments and whether the units are operating with the required permissions.

The issue came to light after the college administration raised concerns about the growing number of industries operating in the area. According to college principal Mahajan, several companies have come up around the institution and some of them do not appear to have their names or licence details prominently displayed at their entry points.

During a visit to the factory on September 8, no company name or licence number was visible at the entrance. When asked about the establishment, workers were reportedly unwilling to disclose who owned the unit or even provide the name of the company operating from the premises.

The lack of visible identification does not, by itself, establish that the factory is unauthorised. However, it raises a basic question: if an industrial unit is legitimately operating, why are its identity and licensing details not readily available at the entrance, and which authority is responsible for checking this?

The concerns extend beyond identification and licensing. Mahajan also allegedly said that the groundwater in the vicinity has developed a foul smell, which he attributed to the increasing number of industries.



Workers of these units are reluctant to disclose the details of owners

VHP bars Muslims

Asks garba and dandiya organisers to verify Aadhaar cards

Varad A. Gokhale
feedback@punemirror.com
@ThePuneMirror



The announcement has triggered a political debate over religious identity and participation in public celebrations

With Navratri still weeks away, a fresh controversy has erupted over who can participate in garba and dandiya events across Maharashtra. The Vishwa Hindu Parishad (VHP) has announced that Muslims should not be allowed to participate in such events during the forthcoming Navratri festival and has asked organisers to introduce identity checks and other entry protocols at venues.

According to VHP national spokesperson and joint secretary Shriraj Nair, the organisation's position stems from its argument that Navratri is fundamentally a religious festival centred on the worship of a Hindu deity and should not be treated merely as a song, dance or entertainment event.

The VHP has asked organisers to check Aadhaar cards at entry gates to verify the legal names and details of attendees. It has also suggested that participants be given a traditional tilak upon entry, which the organisation has described as a means of establishing Hindu identity.

The announcement has triggered a political debate over religious identity, participation in public celebrations and the nature of Maharashtra's garba and dandiya events. The BJP has supported the VHP's position. State BJP spokesperson Keshav Upadhye argued that Islamic religious doctrine does not permit idol worship and said participation in an event centred on idol worship could conflict with the religious beliefs of Muslims themselves. BJP leader Ram Kadam also defended the provision, arguing that people attending a religious celebration should do so with genuine faith and respect. He said there had been instances of people without such reverence entering events and engaging in misconduct, and argued that measures were therefore necessary to prevent such incidents.

Kadam said the issue should be viewed in the broader context of Sanatan Hindu customs, traditions and culture. He maintained that people coming with genuine reverence should not be considered unwelcome, but questioned how someone intending to create trouble or enter with an ulterior motive could be allowed into a religious event.

Opposition parties, however, have sharply criticised the VHP's position. Congress MLA Amin Patel described the proposed exclusion as unconstitutional, while other opposition leaders argued that Maharashtra's festivals have historically provided spaces for communities to participate together rather than being divided along religious lines.

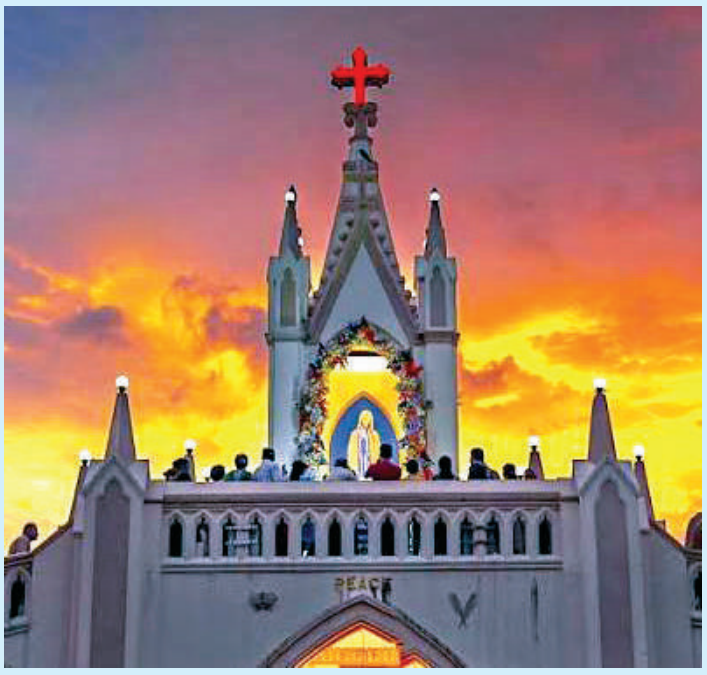
The controversy has also brought recent remarks by RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat into the political debate. Opposition leaders have pointed to Bhagwat's emphasis on universal human dignity and religious harmony and questioned whether the VHP's proposed restrictions are consistent with that broader message.

The issue comes ahead of Navratri, which begins on October 11, and could now become a flashpoint as garba and dandiya organisers prepare for the festival season.

BANDRA GETS READY FOR MOUNT MARY FAIR

Baginning Sept 13, Church to see thousands flocking

Rutuja Joshi
feedback@punemirror.com
@ThePuneMirror



The annual Bandra Fair, one of Mumbai's oldest religious and cultural traditions, will return this month with celebrations centred around the Basilica of Our Lady of the Mount, popularly known as Mount Mary Basilica, in Bandra.

According to the Basilica's official 2026 stall regulations, the Bandra Fair will be held from September 13 to September 20. The week-long celebration is expected to draw pilgrims and visitors from across Mumbai and neighbouring areas.

The fair forms part of the annual celebrations associated with the Feast of the Nativity of the Blessed Virgin Mary, observed on September 8. The religious celebrations at Mount Mary traditionally include a novena leading up to the feast, followed by the popular fair around the Basilica.

The Basilica's official regulations state that 130 temporary stalls have been allotted for this year's fair. The stalls will include religious articles, food, garments, books and other items associated with the annual celebration. According to the guidelines, stalls are scheduled to operate from 6 am to 10 pm during the fair. The Mount Mary shrine has a history spanning several centuries. According to the Basilica, a statue of Our Lady of the Mount was brought to Bandra by Jesuits from Portugal in the 16th century and installed at a small oratory in the area. The shrine subsequently developed into an important pilgrimage centre.

Over the years, the Bandra Fair has grown into a distinctive part of Mumbai's cultural calendar, combining religious observances with a bustling public fair. Visitors traditionally come to the area to offer prayers, light candles and purchase religious articles, while the surrounding streets take on a festive atmosphere with food and other temporary stalls.

The shrine has also hosted several historically significant visitors. Pope Paul VI visited Mount Mary in Bandra on December 5, 1964, during his visit to India for the International Eucharistic Congress in Bombay. The Vatican records his visit to the shrine, while the Basilica also mentions it in its history.

The annual fair is expected to bring increased footfall to Bandra, particularly around the Basilica and surrounding roads. Authorities and organisers have laid down regulations for stall operators covering issues including safety, cleanliness, crowd movement and fire prevention. With the religious celebrations already underway around the feast period, the Bandra Fair will officially take place from September 13 to 20 this year, continuing a tradition that has become an enduring part of Mumbai's religious and cultural landscape.

Pedestrian safety under spotlight

Work for Metro Line 4 underway at Ghatkopar

Rutuja Joshi
feedback@punemirror.com
@ThePuneMirror

Concerns over pedestrian safety have surfaced along LBS Road in Ghatkopar West, where ongoing construction work for Mumbai Metro Line 4 has drawn attention to the condition and availability of pedestrian space near R City Mall.

The stretch opposite R City Mall falls along Lal Bahadur Shastri Marg, one of the major roads connecting parts of Ghatkopar with other eastern suburbs. The location is also close to the proposed Shreyas Cinema Metro station, which is part of the Wadala-Ghatkopar-Mulund-Thane-Kasarvadavali Metro Line 4 corridor. MMRDA documents list Shreyas Cinema among the elevated stations on the corridor.

A concern being raised over the stretch is whether pedestrians will continue to have adequate, unobstructed space once the metro station and its access infrastructure are completed. The issue assumes significance on a road where pedestrian movement already has to compete for limited space with traffic and ongoing infrastructure work.

The question of pedestrian access is particularly relevant because MMRDA's own metro planning documents recognise the need for pedestrian-friendly infrastructure around stations.

Its published design guidelines refer to facilities including footpaths, kerb ramps, road intersections, pedestrian refuges, tactile paving, ramps and lifts, with accessibility standards intended to provide seamless movement around metro stations.

The present construction activity also comes against the backdrop of earlier scrutiny of Metro Line 4 works around the same area. In February this year, concerns were raised after visuals circulated showing what appeared to be cracks on a Metro 4 structure near R City Mall. MMRDA subsequently inspected the location near the proposed Shreyas Cinema station and said the visible line was excess concrete slurry rather than a structural crack. The authority said the material was removed and that the beam was safe and stable.

LBS Road itself has long faced pedestrian and traffic-management challenges. The road passes through densely developed residential and commercial areas, while Metro 4 construction has added another layer of infrastructure activity along the corridor.

For pedestrians, temporary arrangements during construction can be as important as the final design. Clearly marked and continuous walking routes, adequate barricading, safe crossings and sufficient lighting are essential where existing footpaths are affected by construction.

While the claim that the proposed metro exits will ultimately obstruct the footpath could not be independently established from publicly available official documents, the broader question of how pedestrian movement will be protected around the completed station remains relevant.

With Metro Line 4 expected to significantly improve public transport connectivity across the eastern suburbs, residents and commuters will also be watching whether the infrastructure is delivered without compromising the basic space required for pedestrians.

2 held for selling fake notes

2,128 such pieces counting ₹10.64 lakh seized

Varad A. Gokhale
feedback@punemirror.com
@ThePuneMirror

The Mumbai Crime Branch Unit-2 arrested a woman and a man in South Mumbai on Sunday for allegedly selling counterfeit Rs 500 currency notes while passing them off as genuine. Acting on specific information, the police laid a trap near Metro Cinema at Vasudev Balwant Phadke Chowk, where the woman was allegedly caught with 270 fake notes.

Following her arrest, investigators traced the second accused to the Cuffe Parade area. The police allegedly found another 1,878 counterfeit Rs 500 notes in his possession. In total, the operation led to the seizure of 2,128 fake notes with a face value of Rs 10.64 lakh. According to the police, the accused were allegedly attempting to circulate the counterfeit currency by representing it as genuine. The recovery of such a large number of fake notes has prompted investigators to examine where the currency came from, how it entered Mumbai and whether the arrested duo was part of a larger network involved in manufacturing or circulating counterfeit currency.

The Crime Branch subsequently registered a case at Azad Maidan police station under relevant provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita. Further investigation is underway.

The police are also expected to examine the accused persons' movements, contacts and financial transactions as part of the probe. Investigators will seek to establish whether the two were working together and identify any other persons who may have supplied or helped circulate the counterfeit notes.

The seizure also raises a larger concern for businesses and members of the public who handle cash transactions, particularly in crowded commercial areas of South Mumbai. While the police operation has resulted in the recovery of the counterfeit currency before it could be circulated further, investigators now face the important task of tracing its source.

Dombivli market razed

KDMC demolishes illegal set-up in Nilje; landowner booked

Varad A. Gokhale
feedback@punemirror.com
@ThePuneMirror



The Kalyan-Dombivli Municipal Corporation (KDMC) recently demolished and shut an allegedly unauthorised weekly market operating behind Green Park Tower at Lodha Heaven in Nilje, Dombivli, after the civic team faced resistance from vendors and the landowner during the action. A case was subsequently registered against the landowner and market organiser, Raja Patil, for allegedly obstructing municipal staff and manhandling civic employees.

The action was carried out by the E-Ward hawker control team along with the civic body's headquarters hawker control squad, following directions from Municipal Commissioner Abhinav Goel. The operation was led by E-Ward Assistant Commissioner Sachin Tamkhede.

According to civic officials, the situation became tense when vendors and Patil allegedly resisted the demolition drive. Officials alleged that members of the crowd obstructed civic employees from carrying out their duties and that some staff members were manhandled. They further alleged that an attempt was made to drive a vehicle towards municipal personnel. The civic team subsequently sought assistance from Manpada Police. With police intervention, the situation was brought under control, and the market was shut down. A case has been registered at Manpada Police Station against Patil for allegedly obstructing government work and assaulting civic employees.

Following the action, senior officials, including Additional Municipal Commissioner Yogesh Godse and Deputy Commissioner of the Unauthorised Construction Control Department Prasad Borkar, visited the site and inspected the location.

PM INAUGURATES WDFC

It spans 326 km and built at a cost of ₹20,700 crore

| Pramod Patil
feedback@punemirror.com
@ThePuneMirror

Prime Minister Narendra Modi virtually inaugurated three key sections of the Western Dedicated Freight Corridor (WDFC) spanning 326 km, built at a cost of over Rs 20,700 crore, from Gujarat.

Attending the event at JNPT, Uran, were Governor Jishnu Dev Varma, Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis, Deputy Chief Ministers Eknath Shinde and Sunetra Ajit Pawar, Employment Guarantee Scheme Minister and District Guardian Minister Bharat Gogawale, Women and Child Development Minister Aditi Tatkare, along with Members of the Legislative Assembly Prashant Thakur and Mahesh Baldi, and Zilla Parishad President Mangesh Wakdikar.

During the inauguration, PM Modi flagged off the first double-stack container train from Jawaharlal Nehru Port Trust (JNPT) via video conference.

Key Highlights

Infrastructure transformation: Modi emphasised that separating freight and passenger traffic allows over 430 freight trains to run daily. Journeys previously taking 30 hours by road can now be completed in 10 to 12 hours, halving the time required to cover 100 km.

Economic and environmental benefits: The dedicated freight tracks reduce fuel consumption, lower logistics expenses, cut environmental emissions, and streamline the national supply chain.

Rail connectivity and expansion: New railway services, such as those in Chhota Udepur and Alirajpur, are extending rail links to remote tribal regions across Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh, and Maharashtra.

Investment metrics: Highlighting a historic railway budget exceeding Rs 2.75 lakh crore, Modi noted that India has manufactured over 50,000 modern railway coaches and added roughly 2.05 lakh wagons to the network since 2014, establishing the country as a major global manufacturer of coaches, metro cars, and locomotives.


A container train was also flagged off

"With the Eastern Dedicated Freight Corridor already operational, the completion of the Western corridor marks the total realisation of the national Dedicated Freight Corridor network. In Maharashtra alone, the project spans 178 route kilometres across Raigad, Thane, and Palghar districts, representing an investment of over Rs 10,000 crore (including land acquisition costs)," said Governor Jishnu Dev Varma.

"The activation of the New Umargam to JNPT section—part of the 1,500 km Dadri (Uttar Pradesh) to JNPT route—will serve as a major catalyst for Maharashtra's logistics ecosystem. Having handled approximately 38.27 lakh TEUs of container traffic between April and August, JNPT is well-positioned to become India's first port with a capacity exceeding 10 million TEUs by 2030," said Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis.

Key features of corridor

Project scope: Spans 326 km constructed at a cost of approximately Rs 20,778 crore, completing the critical missing link between New Umargam and JNPT. Geographical reach: Connects five key states—Maharashtra, Gujarat, Rajasthan, Haryana/Delhi, and Uttar Pradesh—over a distance of roughly 1,500 km.

Engineering achievements: Constructed through challenging marine clay environments across Palghar, Vasai, Vaitarna, and the Ulhas River region. Features specialized high-clearance overhead structures for double-stack containers, four major tunnels, hundreds of bridges, flyovers, and 147 lakh cubic metres of earthwork.

Logistics and economic impact: Expected to reduce overall national logistics costs from 14% to under 7% of GDP, boost JNPT's container handling capacity by around 15%.

382 passengers fined

Ticket-checking drive at Karjat railway station

| Rutuja Joshi
feedback@punemirror.com
@ThePuneMirror

A special ticket-checking drive conducted at Karjat railway station on Monday, September 7, resulted in 382 passengers being penalised for travelling without valid tickets, carrying unbooked luggage and other violations. A total penalty of Rs 1,74,340 was recovered during the drive.

The operation, described as a fortress ticket-checking drive, was carried out with the deployment of 18 Travelling Ticket Examiners (TTEs), five personnel from the Railway Protection Force (RPF) and an officer from the Commercial Department.

The largest number of violations involved passengers travelling in the second-class compartment without valid tickets. Officials detected 256 such cases, with penalties amounting to Rs 1,32,445 being recovered.

The checking also covered first-class travel. Thirty passengers were found travelling in first class without tickets and were penalised a total of Rs 17,565. In another 22 cases, passengers were found travelling with a ticket that did not correspond to the class of travel. These cases resulted in penalties of Rs 12,940.

Railway officials also acted against passengers carrying unbooked luggage. A total of 73 cases were detected during the drive, with Rs 10,890 collected in penalties. One case of trespassing under Section 147 of the Railways Act was also recorded. The violation resulted in a penalty of Rs 500.

The combined figures from the drive accounted for all 382 cases detected by the checking team and the total Rs 1,74,340 penalty recovered.



Ticket-checking drives are conducted by the railways to discourage ticketless travel and ensure that passengers comply with railway regulations. Such operations also help protect revenue and promote fair travel practices among passengers who purchase tickets before boarding trains.

The presence of TTEs, RPF personnel and a Commercial Department officer during the operation allowed the teams to check different categories of violations at the station. Passengers travelling through Karjat and other stations on the route have been advised to purchase the appropriate ticket before commencing their journey. Railway authorities have urged passengers to carry a valid ticket for the correct class and journey and to ensure that luggage requiring booking is properly declared and booked.

Officials reiterated the importance of following railway rules and appealed to commuters to avoid ticketless travel and other violations.

The railway administration has advised passengers to travel with a valid ticket and maintain dignity while travelling, while warning that passengers found violating rules may face penalties during such checking drives.

2 sent to police custody till Sept 11

They posed as PMO officials at Modi's event in BKC area

#MUMBAI
@ThePTMMumbai

Two arrested individuals, allegedly posing as PMO officials, have been sent to police custody till September 11 by a court. The individuals were arrested by Mumbai Police while trying to enter the venue where Prime Minister Narendra Modi is set to attend an event.

Three men allegedly used a suspicious government identity card and forced their way past mall security while carrying a firearm to enter Jio World Plaza in Mumbai's BKC area, according to police.

"Three men allegedly used a suspicious government ID card and forced their way, armed with a firearm, past mall security into Jio World Plaza, BKC. An FIR has been filed at BKC PS under various BNS sections, including impersonation of a public servant and unlawful entry armed with a weapon. Crime Branch is conducting further investigation. The weapon has been found to be licensed, and two persons have been arrested in this regard. Please note that this incident took place yesterday," Mumbai police said.

Earlier, two individuals were detained by the Mumbai Police from the Nita Mukesh Ambani Cultural Centre (NMACC) in Bandra Kurla Complex (BKC), where Prime Minister Narendra Modi was scheduled to attend an event.

According to the Mumbai Police, one of the suspects, a 24-year-old man posing as an official from the Prime Minister's Office (PMO), attempted to enter the venue on September 7 using a fake identity card. **ANI**

Pea problem at centres

They fail to get cooked; issue reaches district programme office

| Pramod Patil
feedback@punemirror.com
@ThePuneMirror

The Integrated Child Development Project Officer in Panvel has stated that the issue of the peas not cooking has been reported to the District Programme Officer. It came to light that the peas provided to students in Anganwadi centres of Panvel taluka do not get cooked. Despite being subjected to ten to twelve pressure cooker whistles, they remain uncooked, raising urgent questions regarding the quality of the produce.

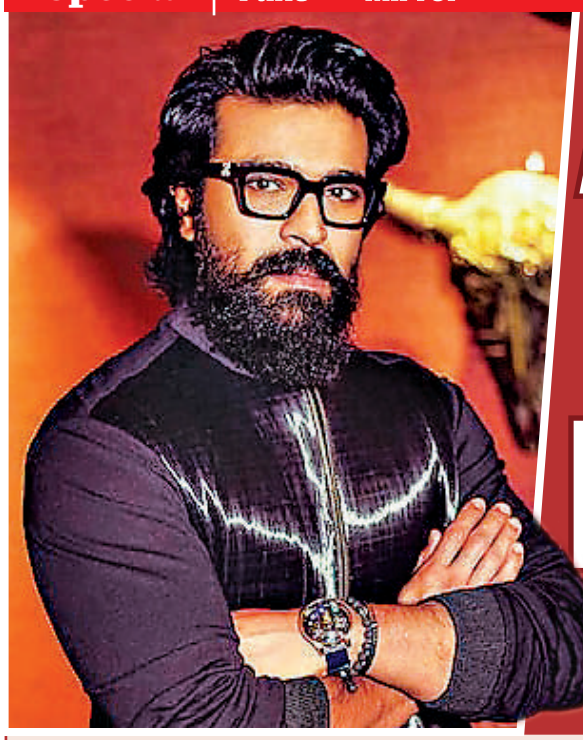
There are a total of 272 Anganwadi centres in Panvel taluka, where students are provided with meals comprising lapsi (a wheat-based dish) and peas. When supervisors inspected 114 of these centres, Anganwadi workers reported that the peas provided to them remained hard even after ten to twelve pressure-cooking whistles.



Preparing these peas requires significantly more time and fuel than usual. Legumes play a crucial role in the nutritional intake of children at Anganwadis, intended to provide essential proteins and nutrients. Therefore, it is imperative that the quality of these food grains is of a high standard. However, complaints about the government-supplied peas failing to cook have sparked concerns regarding how the quality of nutritional food for young children is being monitored.

When questioned about the matter, Integrated Child Development Officer Pravin Patil stated that the issue of the peas not cooking has been reported to the District Programme Officer. A request has been made for a new stock of high-quality, easily cookable peas. He further added that, as a temporary measure, students are currently being provided with lapsi instead of peas.

Attempts to contact the district administration regarding this issue were unsuccessful. There is an urgent need for an inquiry to determine who is responsible for this situation and which officials are accountable for the distribution of such substandard grains. Given that this directly concerns the health of young children, it is vital that an explanation be provided regarding who will be held responsible should any adverse health incidents occur due to the consumption of such poor-quality food.



A MEETING TO REMEMBER

Japan's Biryani Man Serves Ram Charan, Says He Didn't Know the Star at First



For Japanese chef Takamasa Osawa, biryani is more than just a dish. It is a passion that has taken him across South Asia, earned him international recognition, and most recently, brought him into the home of Telugu superstar Ram Charan in Hyderabad.

Known as "Biriyani Osawa," the Japanese chef recently opened up about his memorable experience cooking for Ram Charan and his family. Interestingly, Osawa revealed that when he first received the opportunity, he was not fully aware of just how big a star Ram Charan was.

Cooking for a star

"Honestly, I didn't really know him at first," Osawa shared, adding that he later looked up the actor and watched RRR. That was when he realised that he was about to cook for a global star.

The special culinary experience took place at Ram Charan's residence in Jubilee Hills, Hyderabad, earlier this year. Dressed in his signature black chef's coat, Osawa prepared his much-loved biryani for the actor and his family.

For a chef who has spent years studying biryani, cooking in Hyderabad itself was a special moment. After all, the city is considered one of the world's most iconic biryani destinations. But serving the dish to Ram Charan and his father, veteran actor Chiranjeevi, made the experience even more unforgettable.

Osawa was reportedly introduced to Ram Charan through mutual friends. While he chose not to share further details about the meeting, he had plenty of good things to say about the actor.

Calling Ram Charan an "unbelievable gentleman", the chef recalled a simple gesture that left a lasting impression on him — the actor cleared Osawa's finished plate himself.

Videos and pictures from the visit had earlier gone viral on social media, giving fans a glimpse of the chef preparing biryani and interacting with the actor's family. Ram Charan was seen appreciating the dish for its flavour, aroma and balanced preparation, particularly noting that it was not overloaded with gravy.

The power of food

Osawa's journey with biryani is equally fascinating. His love affair with the iconic South Asian dish reportedly began during a trip to India when he was a young office worker. What started as curiosity eventually turned into a years-long mission to understand and perfect biryani.

Over the years, he travelled through India, Pakistan and Bangladesh, exploring different regional styles and cooking techniques. Today, his small Tokyo restaurant, Biriyani Osawa, is known for its singular focus on the dish and has received a Michelin Bib Gourmand recognition for its food.

From a Japanese office worker discovering biryani during a trip to India to cooking for one of Telugu cinema's biggest stars, Takamasa Osawa's journey is proof that food has the power to cross borders, cultures and even languages.

And for the chef, serving biryani in Hyderabad—to a family that loves the dish as much as Ram Charan's—was truly the icing on the cake.

THE COOKING CONTROVERSY

When Husbands Cook, Why Are Wives Still Judged?

In many Indian households, a husband cooking a meal is still seen as unusual. But strangely, the questions and taunts often land on his wife.

A man chopping vegetables, making rotis or preparing dinner for his family should be an ordinary sight in 2026. Yet, in many Indian homes, it continues to raise eyebrows. And more often than not, the wife ends up facing uncomfortable questions.

"Why isn't she cooking?"



"Does she not know how to cook?"

"Why does he have to do all the work?"

While conversations around equality and shared responsibilities have grown louder, the Indian kitchen remains one of the strongest spaces where traditional gender roles continue to exist.

A recent discussion around husbands cooking at home has once again highlighted this deep-rooted double standard. Even in urban households where both partners work, a man taking charge of the kitchen can still surprise relatives, neighbours and sometimes even domestic help. The situation often becomes more uncomfortable for the wife, who is judged for allowing her husband to cook.

The irony is hard to miss. Celebrity chefs are admired, celebrated and followed by millions. Men who cook professionally are seen as talented and successful. But when the same man enters his own kitchen to cook for his family, the reaction can suddenly change.

Instead of appreciating a shared responsibility, society often questions the woman.

For many wives, the judgement comes from unexpected places — relatives, friends, neighbours and even other women. Some are made to feel that they are failing as wives or mothers simply because their husbands enjoy cooking or willingly share household responsibilities.

The problem, however, is much bigger than cooking.

For generations, Indian women have been expected to manage not just the kitchen but also the invisible responsibilities that come with running a household. Planning meals, buying groceries, ensuring everyone eats on time, cleaning up and thinking about the nutritional needs of the family have largely been considered women's responsibilities.

Even today, when women have careers and contribute financially, household work is often viewed differently. A man helping in the kitchen is praised for being supportive. A woman doing the same work every day is simply expected to do it.

This is where the double standard begins.

A husband cooking dinner should not automatically mean that his wife is neglecting her responsibilities. Similarly, a wife cooking every day should not mean that household work belongs only to her.

Cooking is a life skill. More importantly, managing a home is a shared responsibility.

Interestingly, not every Indian household reacts negatively. Many couples today are breaking these stereotypes by dividing responsibilities based on interest, time and convenience rather than gender. In some homes, husbands enjoy cooking while wives handle other responsibilities. In others, the roles change depending on work schedules.

Perhaps that is what equality inside a home should actually look like — not a strict division of who is supposed to do what, but a partnership.

The next time a husband is seen preparing dinner while his wife relaxes after a long day, perhaps the question should not be, "Why is he cooking?"

Maybe it is time Indian households asked a simpler question: Why does it still surprise us?

DRI seizes gold worth ₹1.10 crore
— The Directorate of Revenue Intelligence (DRI), Mumbai Zonal Unit, busted a syndicate and seized 691.870 grams of 24-carat gold worth approximately Rs 1.10 crore, the agency said.

MPSC chief facing scrutiny?

Rohit Pawar seeks inquiry into Bhimanwar's career; warns of agitation if no action is taken in 3 days

NAGPUR
@ThePuneMirror

MLA Rohit Pawar has claimed that recurring questions are being raised regarding the examination process during Vivek Bhimanwar's tenure as Chairman of the Maharashtra Public Service Commission (MPSC). Pawar urged Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis to take the initiative in ordering an inquiry into Bhimanwar's civil service career to preserve students' trust in the commission.

Pawar stated that he intends to officially request detailed information—backed by evidence—regarding decisions taken by Bhimanwar during his term as RTO Commissioner, as well as various contracts awarded under his leadership. He further claimed that numerous letters were submitted against Bhimanwar on September 1, 2026.


Vivek Bhimanwar

Pawar argued that if allegations involving thousands of crores of rupees in corruption are circulating about Bhimanwar, they must be thoroughly investigated. He appealed to the chief minister to inspect the matter and assign a competent officer to lead the MPSC.

Pawar also raised concerns over the administration of MPSC examinations. Referencing the first recorded MPSC paper leak in 1997, he noted that allegations of paper leaks during the current chairman's tenure represent a serious issue.

He demanded that the chairman should accept moral responsibility and step down if it is proven that a paper was leaked under his watch. To clear doubts among students, Pawar urged the chief minister to intervene and appoint a capable candidate—citing officials like Tukaram Mundhe as an example—to restore credibility to the commission.

Three-day deadline set

Pawar asserted that he has formally raised objections regarding several MPSC examinations using supporting evidence, noting that concerns have been raised over the Group-B, Police Sub-Inspector (PSI), and Agriculture Department exams.

"If we do not receive a positive response within the next three days, protests will be launched in Pune and several other regions across the state. In Pune alone, 50,000 students will take to the streets," Pawar warned.

Concerns over leaked schemes

Pawar also questioned the marking pattern used for the Excise Department examination, explaining that prior knowledge of a marking scheme allows candidates to tailor their preparation and secure higher marks in less time. He warned that if such information leaked from within the MPSC, it constitutes a grave breach. Furthermore, Pawar expressed concern that practice irregularities—such as removing a candidate's name from the PSI examination list only to send them for training, or obtaining officer posts through financial bribery—could undermine the administration.

He demanded that the MPSC issue clear explanations if it denies these allegations, adding, "It is inappropriate to deny allegations initially, only to concede them later."

AGENCIES

MANOJ JARANGE ON FAST

'All issues addressed'

CM Fadnavis assures of open door policy for dialogue

#ANTARWALI SARATI
@ThePuneMirror

Manoj Jarange Patil's indefinite hunger strike demanding Maratha reservation and other measures entered its 11th day on Tuesday. When asked whether Jarange's demands had been met, Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis stated that all raised issues had been addressed, adding, "If they feel there are gaps or hold lingering doubts, they are welcome to raise them, and we will resolve them."

Fadnavis stated, "Whether it is the deputy chief minister or myself, our position is clear: whatever has been granted to the Maratha community to date was delivered by us. The decisions taken so far were made by us, and any future decisions will also be taken by us. Certain hurdles were addressed before decisions were finalised."

"The government has not merely issued orders on paper; the practical benefits are visible to the Maratha community. Everything permissible within the constitutional framework and subject to court rulings will certainly be done. We do not deprive one community to help another community. Our duty is to ensure justice for the Maratha community alongside all other groups," he clarified.

Fadnavis added that the government has not closed the door to dialogue regarding Jarange's protest. "The government always resolves issues through discussion, and steps are being taken in that direction," he said.

Late on Monday night, ministers including Prasad Lad and Uday Samant spoke to Jarange by telephone. Following the conversation, Jarange resumed the medical treatment he had previously paused, focusing attention on the forthcoming talks between the government and the protest leaders.


Manoj Jarange

Jarange criticises Vikhe Patil

Meanwhile, Manoj Jarange launched a sharp attack on Radhakrishna Vikhe Patil, Chairman of the Cabinet Sub-Committee on Maratha Reservation. "Vikhe Patil has caused the greatest harm to the Maratha community. He wasted an entire year by using sweet words," Jarange alleged.

Jarange claimed that Vikhe Patil had promised a decision on the Satara Sansthan Gazetteer within a month, yet a year has passed without fulfillment. He further accused the government of issuing empty assurances regarding certificates based on the Hyderabad Gazette without delivering results on the ground.

"Vikhe Patil should speak the truth now. His stance has damaged the community's interests," Jarange stated, further accusing Vikhe Patil of fulfilling Devendra Fadnavis's agenda.

AGENCIES

Trucks out, devotees in

Mumbai Goa highway clears the way for Ganpati Bappa!

Tushar Shete
tushar.shete@punemirror.com
@ThePuneMirror

In a move that has brought cheer to millions of Ganesh devotees, the Maharashtra government has rolled out a massive relief plan for travellers heading to the Konkan region this festive season. The Transport Department has officially banned all heavy vehicles weighing 16 tonnes or more from plying on the Mumbai Goa National Highway 66 during the peak Ganeshotsav rush.

The decision comes after officials flagged a familiar festive nightmare, endless traffic snarls caused by trucks, trailers and sand carrying vehicles clogging the highway just when lakhs of ST buses and private vehicles are racing home for the celebrations.

Officials clarified that the ban is not meant to choke essential supplies but purely to give festive traffic a smooth run. Local police have also been handed flexible powers, with the Police Commissioner of Navi Mumbai and Superintendents of Police in the concerned districts allowed to relax restrictions based on ground reality.



The order is being seen as a huge sigh of relief for both Konkan residents and outstation devotees who annually dread the chaos of this stretch during Ganeshotsav. With buses, cars and two wheelers set to dominate the highway instead of towering trucks, this year's journey to Konkan may finally be jam free, stress free and full of festive cheer.

When the ban kicks in

- Idol arrival and prep travel: September 11, 2026 (00:01 hrs) to 15 September 2026 (23:00 hrs)
- Five day Ganpati immersion and return rush: September 18, 2026 (08:00 hrs to 23:00 hrs)
- Gauri Ganpati immersion (seven day): September 19, 2026 (08:00 hrs to 23:00 hrs) and September 20, 2026 (till 23:00 hrs)
- Anant Chaturdashi grand final immersion: September 25, 2026 (08:00 hrs) to September 26, 2026 (20:00 hrs)

Who gets a green signal

- Vehicles carrying import export cargo from JNPT and Jaigad ports
- Milk, petrol, diesel and cooking gas cylinder tankers
- Medicines, liquid oxygen and perishable goods including vegetables and food grains
- Ambulances, police vehicles, fire brigade and disaster management units
- Vehicles carrying material for the ongoing widening and repair work of the Mumbai Goa Highway, provided they carry a valid pass from traffic or highway police

HC rejects Rahul Gandhi's plea

Criminal defamation to move forward

#MUMBAI
@ThePuneMirror

The Bombay High Court on Tuesday rejected the plea filed by Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, challenging a criminal defamation complaint over his alleged remarks against Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

Upholding the lower court's decision, a single bench of Justice N R Borkar stated that it found no 'perversity and illegality' in the order issued by the magistrate. Consequently, the criminal defamation proceedings against the Congress leader will move forward in the Girgaon Metropolitan Magistrate Court, requiring his personal appearance.

The legal matter stems from 2019, when the Girgaon Metropolitan Magistrate issued summons to Gandhi after concluding that a prima facie case of criminal defamation was established against him under Section 500 of the Indian Penal Code (IPC). Gandhi subsequently moved the High Court to quash the proceedings.

The complainant opposed Gandhi's petition before the High Court. Earlier in November 2021, the High Court had granted interim relief to the Congress leader by directing the magistrate court to defer the hearing, thereby exempting Gandhi from personal appearance until a final decision was reached on his petition. **ANI**



feedback@punemirror.com
facebook.com/thepunemirror
twitter.com/thepunemirror
instagram.com/thepunemirror

'PAYING THE PRICE OF WAR'

Turkish Prez slams Israel for derailing US-Iran MoU, sabotaging peace efforts

#ANKARA
@ThePuneMirror

Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdogan on Monday accused Israel of sparking the West Asia conflict and intentionally sabotaging regional peace efforts, stating that the global economy and regional nations are paying the price for Israeli "schemes and provocations".

According to a statement published by his office on X, Erdoğan levelled sharp criticism against Israel's leadership, holding them directly responsible for derailing the 14-point Islamabad Memorandum of Understanding signed between Iran and the US in June, intended to bring relief and ease military tensions.

"Not just the Iranian people and our brotherly Gulf countries, but everyone, whether directly involved or not, is paying the price of the war that started with Israel's schemes and provocations," Erdogan said after a Presidential Cabinet meeting.

Highlighting diplomatic setbacks, Erdogan asserted that Israeli actions actively undermined agreements aimed at de-escalating conflicts involving Iran, the United States, and regional actors.



Smoke rises in southern Lebanon following Israeli strike as seen from Marjayoun on Monday, Sept 7
REUTERS/KARAMALLAH DAHER

"It was, once again, Israel's lies and acts of sabotage that derailed the Islamabad Accord, which had brought relief to our entire region," Erdoğan stated.

Warning that long-term regional stability remains out of reach as long as current hardline policies persist, the Turkish leader called for an immediate shift in approach toward diplomacy.

"As long as this radical mentality that regards even the slightest prospect of peace as a threat to itself remains unchanged, the 'storm of crisis' in our region will not subside," Erdoğan added.

Netanyahu firm on Iran 'regime' change

On the other hand, Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said that the Iranian government's downfall is approaching while it struggles for survival, adding that a further objective remains to be fulfilled.

During a governmental meeting held for a Rosh Hashanah Toast on Sunday, he made these observations.

"We are determined to defend ourselves; we are determined to strike our enemies. They are not attacking us. Iran is refraining from doing so, and it knows why. Of course, it could err and make the mistake of attacking us anyway. It will suffer a blow it cannot even imagine," the Israeli Prime Minister's Office quoted him as saying.

He maintained that Israel stands as the premier superpower across West Asia while issuing a caution to adversaries: "Do not try us."

"I say to our enemies: Do not try us. This (Israeli) people know how to unite in moments of testing, and right now it is the strongest superpower in West Asia, and some say even beyond," Netanyahu added.

"The achievements are immense, but there is still more to complete. I mean, first and foremost, the toppling of the (Iranian) regime. This regime in Iran — its end is near. It is weak, it is fighting for its life, it is faltering. And there is another mission to complete, which we are determined to bring about," Netanyahu highlighted.

AGENCIES

US steps up blockade

Iran threatens Gulf exclusion zone as US redirects 94 ships

#WASHINGTON
@ThePuneMirror

US Central Command forces operating in the Arabian Sea on Monday (local time) redirected nearly 100 commercial vessels and boarded multiple ships, stepping up the maritime blockade against Iran amid fresh threats of a "recalibrated" military posture from Tehran.

In a post on X, the US CENTCOM detailed the operational metrics of its naval blockade enforcement, accompanied by images of night carrier strike group sorties.

"An E/A-18G aircraft launches from the flight deck of USS George H.W. Bush (CVN 77) during night flight operations while the ship supports enforcement of the U.S. blockade against Iran in the Arabian Sea," CENTCOM posted. "As of Sept. 7, CENTCOM forces have redirected 94 commercial vessels, disabled 3 and boarded 2 to ensure complete compliance with the blockade."

Meanwhile, Iran's Supreme National Security Council Secretary Mohsen Rezaei warned Washington that Tehran has "fundamentally recalibrated" its military operational posture toward US warships and bases, threatening to establish a maritime exclusion zone across the Persian Gulf in response to American economic sanctions.

In a post on X, he stated that recent Iranian missile tests served as a direct warning to the US. "In recent days, Washington has received a clear warning from Iran's new missiles," Rezaei posted. "Economic warfare will be met by a maritime exclusion zone across the Persian Gulf to the blockade perimeter. The operational posture toward U.S. warships and bases has been fundamentally recalibrated."

Earlier in the day, Rezaei said Tehran will keep the Strait of Hormuz open if the United States stops threatening or attacking Iran.

In an interview with Iranian state broadcaster Islamic Republic of Iran Broadcasting (IRIB) on Sunday, Rezaei said Iran's position on the strategic waterway was directly linked to Washington's military posture towards Tehran.

"Iran will commit to keeping the Strait of Hormuz open when the US neither threatens nor attacks Iran," Rezaei told IRIB.

AGENCIES

Saudi energy infra hit

70 injured in Houthi attack; ops suspended

#RIYADH
@ThePuneMirror

Saudi Arabia's Energy Ministry stated that multiple energy facilities and installations located within the southern province of the kingdom came under attack on Tuesday morning, reportedly leaving around 70 people injured.

A formal statement released on X detailed that the hostile incidents triggered fires across various locations and caused a brief suspension of select operations, while official emergency teams rushed to ensure personnel safety, protect infrastructure, and restore normal workflow continuity.

The ministry further noted that comprehensive evaluations of the structural damage are currently underway, adding that all individuals who sustained injuries are receiving proper medical care.

These strikes formed part of an assault by Yemen's Iran-backed Houthi movement, prompting the Saudi-led coalition in Yemen to announce on Tuesday a firm response to the latest outbreak of hostilities.



Indian Navy's guided missile destroyer INS Visakhapatnam deployed in the Gulf of Aden responded to a distress call from MV Merlin Luanda after it caught fire due to a suspected drone strike by Houthi rebels in Yemen ANI FILE PHOTO

The Houthis, who control the most populous parts of Yemen and much of the north, have been launching attacks towards Saudi Arabia since declaring a naval blockade against Riyadh in July, with strikes targeting its vessels in the Red Sea.

Characterising the escalation as dangerous, the spokesperson for the Saudi-led coalition in Yemen stated on Tuesday that the insurgent faction deliberately targeted civilian and economic entities in the world's largest oil exporter and de facto OPEC leader.

Colonel Turki al-Malki emphasised in a formal statement published on X, "The coalition will take all necessary operational measures to deter this terrorist militia and resolutely confront its hostile approach." The official briefing added that the coordinated Houthi operations struck targets situated within the cities of Abha, Khamis Mushait, Jazan, and Najran.

Furthermore, a report published on Monday by the Financial Times indicated that Aramco's Jazan oil facilities were hit in new strikes, with damage assessments currently in progress.

AGENCIES

HEALTH TIP: Antibiotics are powerful medications used to treat and fight bacterial infec tions by killing bacteria or stopping them from growing.



Taking antibiotics unnecessarily or incorrectly causes bacteria to adapt, creating drug-resistant 'superbugs' that are hard to treat.

ASK THE SEXPERT



DR ROHAN JAHAGIRDAR
Psychiatrist & Sexpert

1 I am a 34-year-old man. I have great sex only on the right side of my bed and whenever I have it on the left side I face issues with my performance. What should I do?
Dear Sir, you need to go see a doctor and check yourself for OCD. Until then, you can continue having sex on the side where you can perform. Sexual disorders do not occur based on which side of the bed you are having sex. Hope you get that RIGHT!

2 I am a 45-year-old female. I have been suffering with hypothyroidism for sometime. I feel my drive has gone down and I have become a little irritable. Can that happen?
Ma'am,Yes the hypothyroidism can directly affect the sexual drive and should improve as you get treated. However, given your age also consult a doctor for symptoms of menopause which can also have an impact on your mood and sexual life.

3 I am a 19-year-old male. I had bought a pack of condoms six months back. I haven't got a chance to use them. How long can they remain unused?
My friend please check the expiry date on the packet! They can remain effective and safe with proper storage for upto 3 years, however, I sincerely hope that you don't have to wait that long!

4 I am a 29-year-old female. My boyfriend is extremely sensitive and emotional. Even if I talk about any other guy he gets insecure and starts comparing, when we have sex he takes a lot of time to open and put on a condom and that sometimes annoys me. How do I communicate that to him without hurting him?
Dear Ma'am, you can help him in the process of putting on the condom. That will make the act more sensual and since he is sensitive you will hence not hurt his feelings. However, you need to understand your boyfriend might have anxiety issues and you will need to address them eventually!

SEND YOUR QUERIES RELATED TO SEXUAL PROBLEMS TO
sexpert@punemirror.com



MINUTE SHARDS ARE BIG WORRY!

'Bacteria exposed to microplastic getting resistant to antibiotics'

In a startling discovery, a team of Boston University researchers found that bacteria exposed to microplastics became resistant to multiple types of antibiotics commonly used to treat infections.

Microplastics -- tiny shards of plastic debris -- are all over the planet. They have made their way up food chains, accumulated in oceans, clustered in clouds and on mountains, and been found inside our bodies at alarming rates.

Scientists have been racing to uncover the unforeseen impacts of so much plastic in and around us.

One possible, and surprising, consequence: more drug-resistant bacteria.

They say this is especially concerning for people in high-density, impoverished areas like refugee settlements, where discarded plastic piles up and bacterial infections spread easily.

The study is published in Applied and Environmental Microbiology.

"The fact that there are microplastics all around us, and even more so in impoverished places where sanitation may be limited, is a striking part of this observation," says Muhammad Zaman, a Boston University College of Engineering professor of biomedical engineering who studies antimicrobial resistance and refugee and migrant health.

"There is certainly a concern that this could present a higher risk in communities that are disadvantaged, and only underscores the need for more vigilance and a deeper insight into [microplastic and bacterial] interactions."

It's estimated that there are 4.95 million deaths associated with antimicrobial-resistant infections each year. Bacteria become resistant to antibiotics for many different reasons, including the misuse and overprescribing of medications, but a huge factor that fuels resistance is the microenvironment -- the immediate surroundings of a microbe -- where bacteria and viruses replicate.

At Boston University (BU), researchers rigorously tested how a common bacteria, Escherichia coli (E. coli), reacted to being in a closed environment with microplastics.

"The plastics provide a surface that the bacteria attach to and colonize," says Neila Gross (ENG'27), a BU PhD candidate in materials science and engineering and lead author of the study.

Once attached to any surface, bacteria create a biofilm -- a sticky substance that acts like a shield, protecting the bacteria from invaders and keeping them affixed securely.

Even though bacteria can grow biofilms on any surface, Gross observed that the microplastic supercharged the bacterial biofilms so much that when antibiotics were added to the mix, the medicine was unable to penetrate the shield.

"We found that the biofilms on microplastics, compared to other surfaces like glass, are much stronger and thicker, like a house with a ton of insulation," Gross says. "It was staggering to see."

The rate of antibiotic resistance on the microplastic was so high compared to other materials, that she performed the experiments multiple times, testing different combinations of antibiotics and types of plastic material.

Each time, the results remained consistent. Gross and Zaman say that the next step in their research is to figure out if their findings in the lab translate to the outside world.

How Antibiotics Work

- **Targeting Bacteria:** They disrupt bacterial cell walls or stop protein production, leaving human cells unharmed
- **Bacterial vs. Viral:** They only treat bacterial infections like strep throat or urinary tract infections. They do not work on viral illnesses like colds, the flu, or most coughs

Common Types

- **Penicillins:** Includes amoxicillin and penicillin for ear, sinus, and skin infections
- **Macrolides:** Includes azithromycin and erythromycin for respiratory and skin issues
- **Tetracyclines:** Includes doxycycline for acne and tick-borne illnesses
- **Fluoroquinolones:** Includes ciprofloxacin for serious urinary or respiratory tracts infections

Safe Usage, Resistance

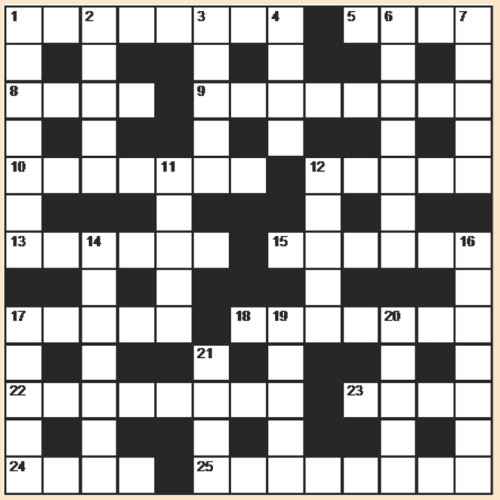
- **Complete the Course:** Always finish the entire prescription, even if you feel better, so the infection does not return
- **Prevent Resistance:** Taking antibiotics unnecessarily or incorrectly causes bacteria to adapt, creating drug-resistant 'superbugs that are hard to treat
- **Side Effects:** Common reactions include nausea, upset stomach, or diarrhoea



Chai-Time

Kidzone, Pune Mirror, email us at mirrorfeatures@gmail.com

QUICK 6688



ACROSS
1 Terms of endearment (3,5)
5 Pay attention to (4)
8 Take it easy (4)
9 Salad vegetable (8)
10 Plod wearily (7)
12 Find fault with (5)
13 Officers in training? (6)
15 Ski race (6)
17 Breezy (5)
18 Utter while crying (7)
22 Seaport in east China (8)
23 Word with Malshej or Western (4)
24 Mark of servitude (4)
25 Nonsense verse (8)

DOWN
1 Pertaining to fever (7)
2 Puccini opera (5)
3 Old spiked clubs (5)
4 Of like kind (4)
6 To involve others in perplexity (7)
7 Bo ____ : No. 10 heroine? (5)
11 Terse, condensed and forcible (5)
12 Himachal Pradesh's ___ Valley (5)
14 Copenhagen is its capital (7)
16 Of marriage (7)
17 Wishy – ___ : feeble in quality or character? (5)
19 Don't take it ___ down : stand up to it? (5)
20 Patna locale (5)
21 Small tool-store (4)

FOR ANSWER SCAN ↓

Please send copies of your children's artworks along with a photo of the artist in A4 size.
Do mention their age and the name of the school they attend. You can also mail us unpublished poems by children.





Kaira Gautam Nathani, 7 years, Alphonsa High, School





Krisha Kiran Soniwal, 8 years, Hutchings High School, Pune

Since 1995
Lokmanya
Multipurpose Co-op. Society Ltd. (Multi-State)
Head Office - Pune, Maharashtra
Do the right thing today for their tomorrow!
PRESENTS
Pune Times Mirror
KIDSZONE





Rasagnya Rallabhandi, 7 years, Indo Scots Global School, Wagholi





Samar Chugh, 6 years, The Bishop's School, Kalyani Nagar

WHAT YOUR STARS SAY TODAY

Aries
March 21 - April 20

The rush around you is dizzying... Take a moment to center yourself in calm. You need to shield yourself from the surrounding commotion so you can find your footing again and feel steady.

Taurus
April 21 - May 20

You'll need to slow down your frantic pace. Do it without guilt—before you burn out. Your diet is nudging you toward imbalances, so it's a good idea to take a clear, honest look at your eating habits.

Gemini
May 21 - June 21

You'll need to slow down your frantic pace. Do it without guilt—before you burn out. Your diet is nudging you toward imbalances, so it's a good idea to take a clear, honest look at your eating habits.

Cancer
June 22 - July 23

A family influence is throwing a wrench into your day-to-day life today. Whether it's rooted in the past or not, it's still very much at work. Take a moment to question it—so you can reconnect with your own values, free from those outside influences.

Leo
July 24 – August 23

You're finally going to feel the positive results of everything you put in last month. Great joys are on the horizon. You can breathe out, relax, and give more time to the people you love. Make the most of it—plan a warm, friendly evening with the ones who matter to you.

Virgo
August 24 - September 23

Today, you'll assert yourself with ease and feel more open to constructive conversations. You'll feel truly understood and supported—so it's an ideal day to negotiate and get what you want!

Libra
September 24 - October 22

Because you're so naturally sociable, you can count on your friendships—and new people you'll meet—to bring easy, enjoyable conversations and plenty of bright moments. Today's energy is all about feeling relaxed and in a festive mood. Let it help you step out of your usual routine.

Scorpio
October 23 - November 22

You have a real gift for drawing favors to you. Your charm opens every door. You move with a calm, measured grace—almost instinctively. Don't try to rush the rhythm. Your energy stays steadily positive.

Sagittarius
November 23 - December 22

It's a highly active day—and it can be surprisingly profitable too. If you find yourself in an argument with someone, pause for a moment and ask whether you're fighting for a path that just doesn't fit you.

Capricorn
December 23 - January 20

Your optimism and confidence will earn you the admiration of everyone around you. No one can resist you today! Keep following your path with optimism—but don't forget to watch your diet to stay in balance.

Aquarius
January 21 - February 19

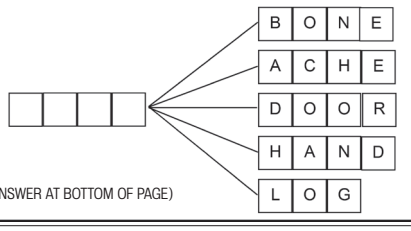
You need to have fun and break out of your routine. That's what will give your relationships a second wind. If you deny this truth, your frustration will only grow stronger today.

Pisces
February 20 - March 20

Your optimism is rising, and it helps you spot the bright side of everything. Good news is on the way—just don't push it too far. Put your energy where it matters, and avoid spreading yourself thin.

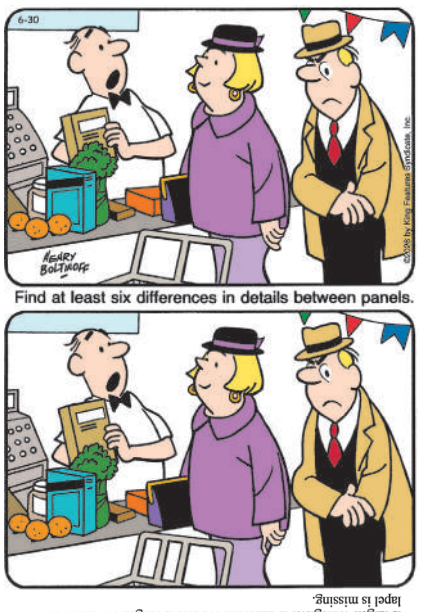
DOUBLE - BARRELLED

What word can be placed in front of the five words shown to form in each case another word ?



(ANSWER AT BOTTOM OF PAGE)

HOCUSFOCUS



Find at least six differences in details between panels.

Differences: 1. Cart handle is different. 2. Finger is moved. 3. Box is larger. 4. Register is different. 5. Purse is longer. 6. Portion of lapel is missing.

ANSWER FOR DOUBLE-BARRELLED : Back

Published by Parmeshwar Kawale for Lexicon Media Private Limited. Editor, Mumbai: S. Balakrishnan, responsible for selection of news under PRB Act. © All rights reserved. Reproduction of whole or in part without written permission is prohibited

Pune Times Mirror | 10
Wednesday, September 9, 2026
feedback@punemirror.com
facebook.com/thepunemirror
twitter.com/thepunemirror
instagram.com/thepunemirror

'Agar Pancham hota, woh tum par fakhar karta'





The world of Indian music has witnessed many iconic collaborations, but some bonds go far beyond recording studios and hit songs. One such special relationship was shared between legendary singer Asha Bhosle and musician-singer Adnan Sami.

On what would have been Asha Bhosle's 93rd birth anniversary on September 8, a heartwarming memory of her appreciation for Adnan Sami has once again brought the two musicians' beautiful association into the spotlight. Asha Bhosle had once told Adnan that, after her late husband and legendary composer R.D. Burman, popularly known as Pancham, he was the one who understood and used her voice in the best possible way.

Her compliment carried even more emotional weight when she reportedly told him, "Agar Pancham hota toh woh tum par fakhar karta" — meaning that if Pancham had been alive, he would have been proud of Adnan.

For any musician, receiving appreciation from Asha Bhosle would be special. But being compared to the musical understanding of R.D. Burman was undoubtedly one of the biggest compliments Adnan Sami could receive.

Adnan's admiration for Asha Bhosle and R.D. Burman also goes back to his childhood. He has spoken about being fascinated by both legends from a young age and even recalled watching them perform in London. His admiration eventually turned into a close musical and personal association with Asha Bhosle.

The connection between Asha and Adnan was rooted in their shared love for experimentation and music that went beyond conventional boundaries. Asha Bhosle herself was known for constantly reinventing her sound. From energetic cabaret numbers and romantic melodies to classical compositions and ghazals, her voice could effortlessly adapt to different styles. Her collaborations with R.D. Burman remain among the most celebrated partnerships in the history of Hindi film music.

R.D. Burman had an extraordinary understanding of Asha's voice and pushed her to explore new sounds, rhythms and expressions. Songs like Aaja Aaja, Piya Tu Ab Toh Aaja, Dum Maro Dum and Chura Liya Hai Tumne became timeless examples of their creative chemistry.

Perhaps that is why Asha's words to Adnan Sami meant so much. She saw in him a musician who understood the many shades and possibilities of her voice.

As fans remember Asha Bhosle and her extraordinary musical journey, this emotional anecdote also highlights another beautiful part of her legacy — her ability to recognise, encourage and support talent. And for Adnan Sami, her words remain a musical honour that few artists could ever hope to receive.

Some compliments win awards. Others become a lifetime memory. And this one, coming from Asha Bhosle, was undoubtedly priceless.

Nora Fatehi faces defamation suit

Bollywood actor and dancer Nora Fatehi has landed in legal trouble after an aviation company filed a Rs 3-crore civil defamation suit against her over her social media comments about a chartered aircraft.

Dunes Aviation has approached a Gandhinagar court, alleging that Nora Fatehi's remarks about one of its aircraft caused serious damage to the company's reputation and business. The actor had reportedly described the aircraft as a "miniature", a "toy" and a "Lego airplane" in videos shared on her social media account.

According to reports, the incident dates back to December last year when Nora was travelling from Mumbai to Jaipur in a Cessna Citation CJ2 aircraft. During the journey, she recorded videos from inside the chartered plane and later posted them on Instagram.



However, what may have appeared to be a casual social media comment has now turned into a major legal dispute.

Dunes Aviation has alleged that Nora's comments were "derogatory and reckless" and negatively affected its commercial operations. The aviation company has reportedly claimed that the actor's remarks led to cancellations and a decline in bookings.

The company has alleged that bookings dropped by around 15 to 20 per cent following Nora's social media posts. It has also pointed out that Nora's massive social media following amplified the impact of her comments and allegedly resulted in reputational damage and loss of goodwill.

Apart from seeking Rs 3 crore in damages, Dunes Aviation has also reportedly requested the court to direct the removal of social media content containing references to the aircraft. The company has additionally sought a public clarification from her.

Defending the aircraft, Dunes Aviation has maintained that the plane was standard and appropriately sized for the Mumbai-Jaipur journey. The company has further stated that the aircraft was DGCA-certified, airworthy and lawfully operated under a valid Non-Scheduled Operator's Permit.

The suit was reportedly filed earlier this year and the matter is scheduled to be heard by Senior Civil Judge R Agarwal on September 25. The development has once again sparked conversations around celebrity influence and social media responsibility. With celebrities commanding millions of followers, even casual comments or humorous observations can quickly reach a massive audience and potentially impact brands and businesses.

Apoorva Mukhija breaks silence on NYU admission rumours

Social media influencer and content creator Apoorva Mukhija, popularly known as 'The Rebel Kid', has finally addressed claims that she allegedly paid a donation to secure admission to New York University's Stern School of Business.

Apoorva, who recently moved to New York to pursue her master's degree, found herself at the centre of an online debate after social media users questioned how she secured admission to the prestigious business school. Some posts even claimed that she had donated money to get her seat at NYU.

Now, the influencer has hit back at the allegations in her latest YouTube Storytime video, making it clear that her admission was based on her academic achievements, professional experience and interview performance — and not a donation.

Reacting to the speculation, Apoorva reportedly questioned why people believed she needed to "buy" her way into business school. She said she did not have the kind of money people were claiming she had donated and jokingly added that the university fees themselves felt expensive enough.



The content creator went on to highlight her academic background and years of professional experience. According to Apoorva, she has worked with some of the top brands in India and built a successful digital career over the past five years.

Apoorva pointed towards the business she has created through social media. With millions of followers and subscribers across Instagram and YouTube, she said her content creation journey has grown into a business with employees and a dedicated team working with her.

She also mentioned her experience in reality TV and acting while explaining why she believed she was a strong candidate for a business school programme. Confidently defending herself, Apoorva said that her communication and interview skills have always been among her strengths. The Rebel Kid's decision to move to New York has itself generated plenty of discussion online.